

This past weekend my weekly visit “home” to California was the last real free weekend before I start my highly anticipated stream of Sierra backpack trips for most of the summer. Due to a minor leg injury I only ended up hiking one day out of the weekend but it was a 12 hour 15 mile hike in the San Gabriel’s with 4,000 ft of gain that was visible from last week’s hike.



This is a view from this weekend’s hike. The peak with the snow is Mt Baldy / Mt San Antonio. The peak to the right is none other than Big Iron which John and I did the week before.

View of Baldy from Iron:



This was officially a scout for my Sierra Club off trail provisional evaluation hike. Besides Kim I had Mark Roberts of WTC fame and the person who would be evaluating me for the actual hike and Dave Driscoll who is one of the hikers from San Diego who comes up to do the LA mountains fairly often.

In a rather un-Matt-like move I managed to forget my camera back at the carpool point. As a result this was one of the few occasions I've been out camera-less and I was worried I'd miss something good like a bear attack or helicopter rescue. Fortunately Dave had a camera on him and served as the photographer for our outing.

Our cheerful fill-in photographer Dave since he appears in so few of the other pictures:



From the carpool point there's quite a drive to the trailhead which is the furthest you can go East along the Angeles Crest / highway 2 road before the long term closure after Islip Saddle.

The 4 of us left the car and started up the trail 8:30 am. We wouldn't make it back until almost 12 hours later when it was dark enough to almost require headlamps.

The route was only ~15 miles and 4,000 ft of gain which isn't much in the scheme of things. As a comparison Iron last weekend was 14 miles and 7,000 ft of gain but that had been all on trail. The difference here was the route I was taking us along included some significant cross country sections including a drop of over 1,000 ft into a large canyon and a direct climb up the other side. Much fun but it makes for slower going.



It was a depressingly sunny day and the biggest weather issue was trying to stay cool during our climbs and keeping the swarm of bugs at bay whenever we stopped.



The initial part of the hike was along the well used Pacific Crest Trail which is a 2600+ mile trail that allows you to hike from the Mexican border all the way to Canada. We came across two thru hikers, one of which Kim claimed to recognize from the PCT kickoff a few weekends ago.

Despite the fact we were at a relatively low elevation (~7,000 ft) there were still patches of snow in certain sheltered areas.



It wasn't enough to impede our passage but we had to watch our footing here and there.

The first peak, Mt Hawkins, was directly off the trail. We bagged that and headed down the ridge to the second peak, a small bump named Copter Ridge.



From the second peak, Copter, we basically dropped straight down the canyon. With hiking poles this was passable if steep.



The bottom of the canyon had a running stream with a fair amount of water. We picked our way across using rocks and fallen trees and paused to wet our hats before starting the long and hot climb up the other side of the canyon.







Switchbacks are for sissies. Real masochists go straight up.



Everyone had so much fun climbing those vertical hillsides there wasn't a complaint in the bunch...well, maybe not quite.

We were all feeling a bit run down when we popped up on the far ridge but we were far from done at this point. First we headed further down the ridge to South Hawkins which used to contain a fire lookout which at some point burned down.



Now they have debris, melted glass, and a toilet with no walls:





It was easier going now but we were a bit tired from the climb so we moved slower as we picked our way back to the PCT.





We made it back to the car just before 8 pm. We were in a hurry to get home at that point as Dave had to drive back to San Diego for an early morning appointment and I had a 6:45 am flight to Boise but overall a nice day of hiking. The official outing will happen June 27th when I'm sure it's going to be much warmer.

